PRODUCT WALKTHROUGH

Paperlane

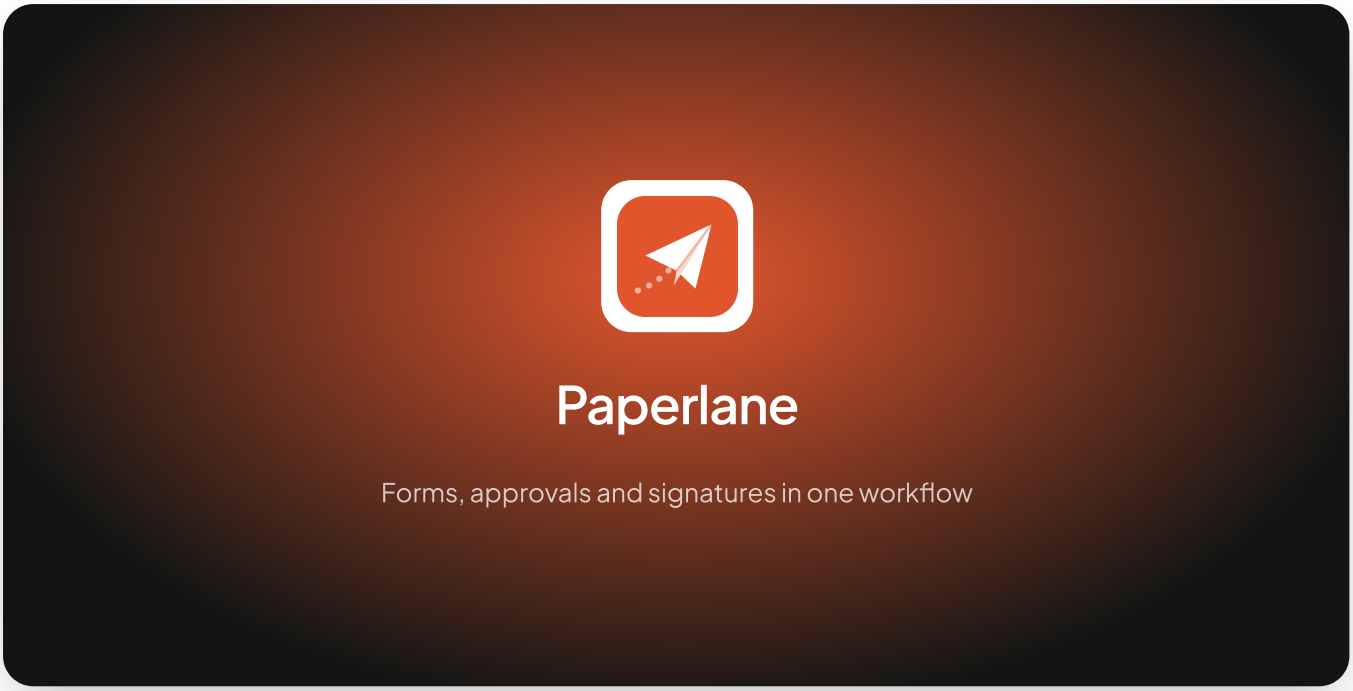
Forms, approvals and signatures in one workflow

Feature Guide & Screen-by-Screen Reference · November 11, 2026

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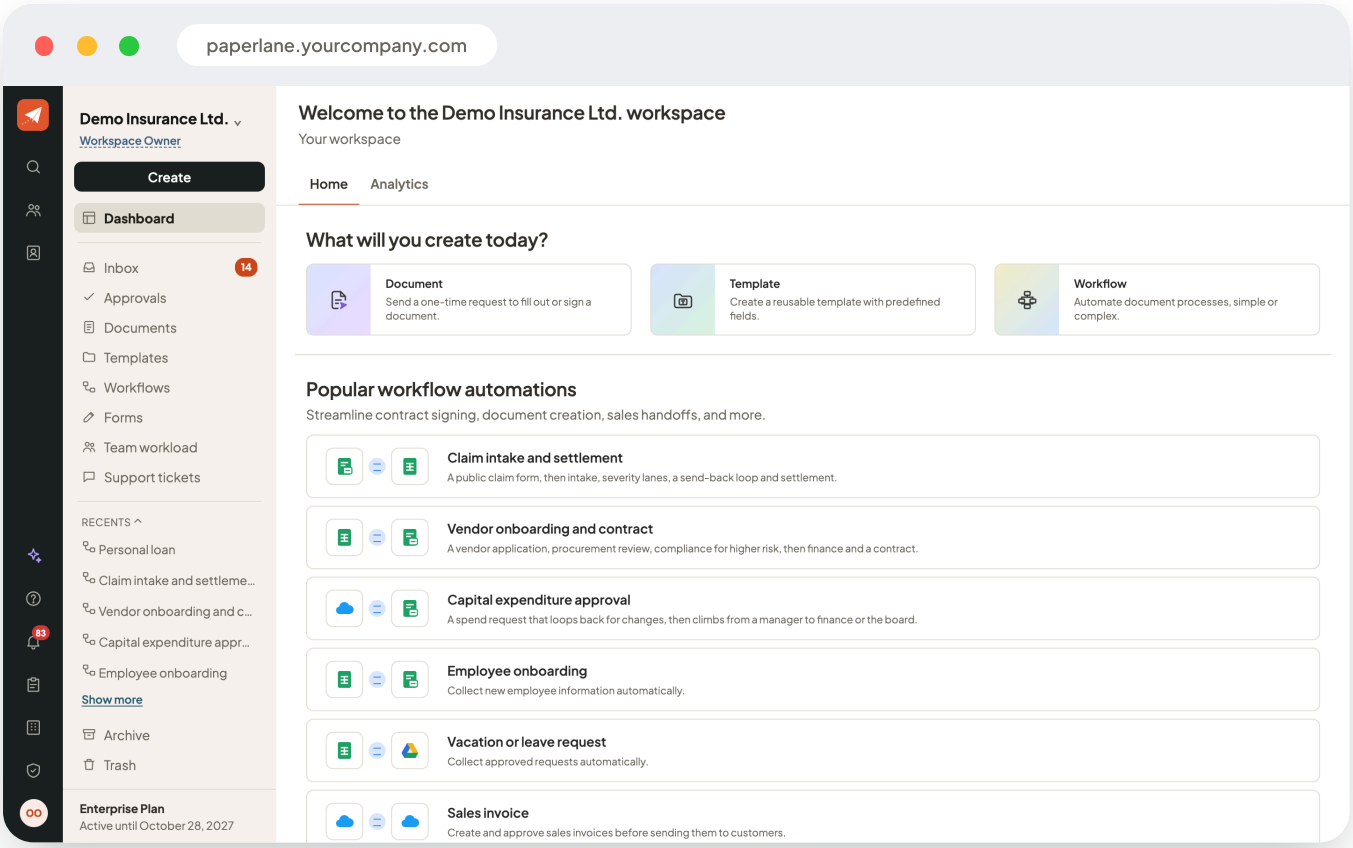
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ABOUT THIS GUIDE

Forms, approvals and signatures in one workflow.

Paperlane is open-source document-workflow software: a visual workflow builder, drag-and-drop forms, e-signatures, approvals, bots and AI, built on Django and run on your own servers. This guide follows one realistic process, a personal loan, from the first form to a sealed, verifiable record.

- Every screen comes from the built-in demo data (`seed_demo`, `seed_stories`, `seed_bank_demo`)
- Self-hosted: your servers, your database (PostgreSQL or SQLite), your keys
- Licensed under AGPL-3.0



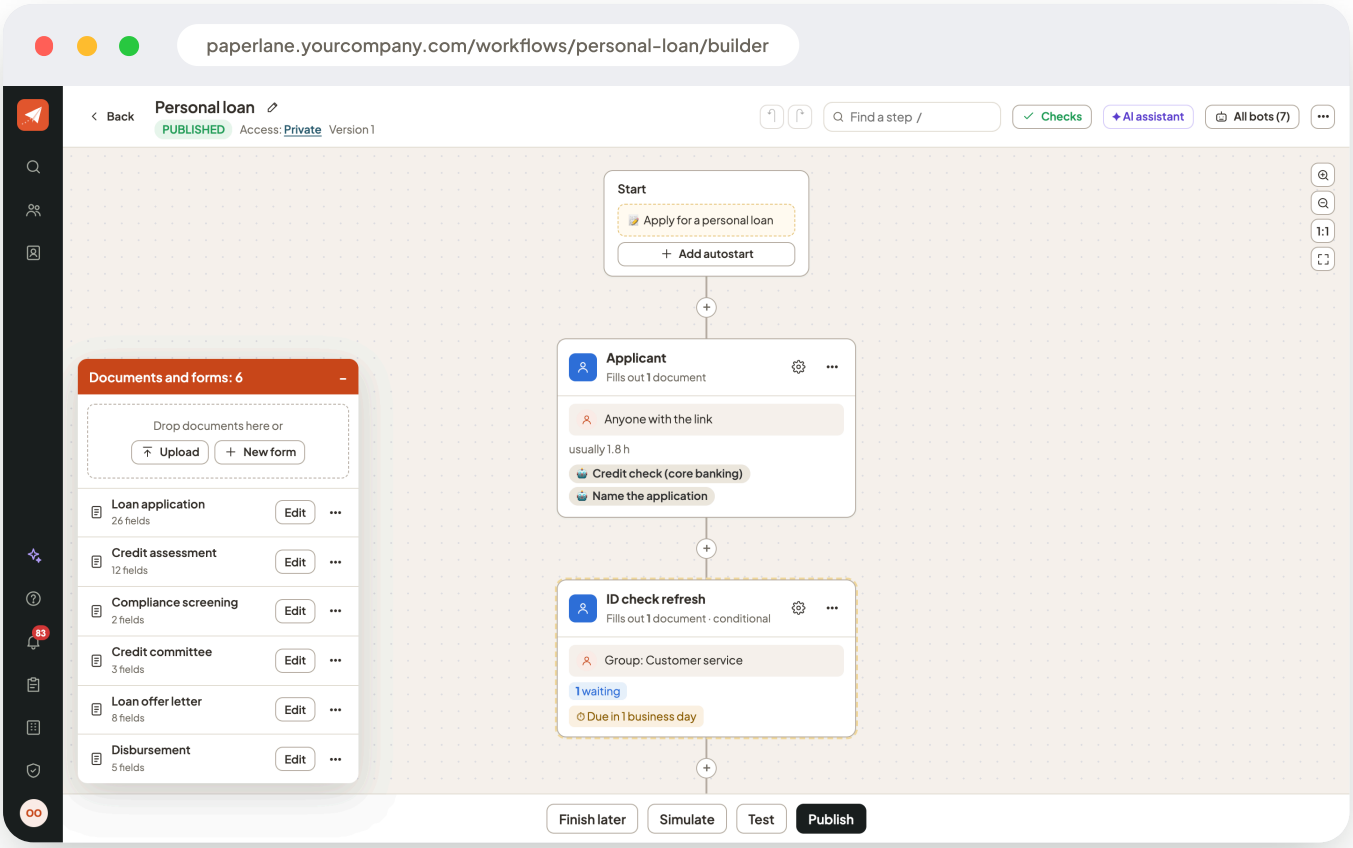
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GET STARTED

Your workspace

The home page is where new work begins. Create a one-off document to send for filling or signing, a reusable template, or a full multi-step workflow. Popular automations give you a working process to publish as it is or adapt.

- Document, template and workflow in one click
- Ready-made workflows for claims, vendor onboarding, capital expenditure, onboarding, leave and invoices
- Recents and an inbox count in the sidebar



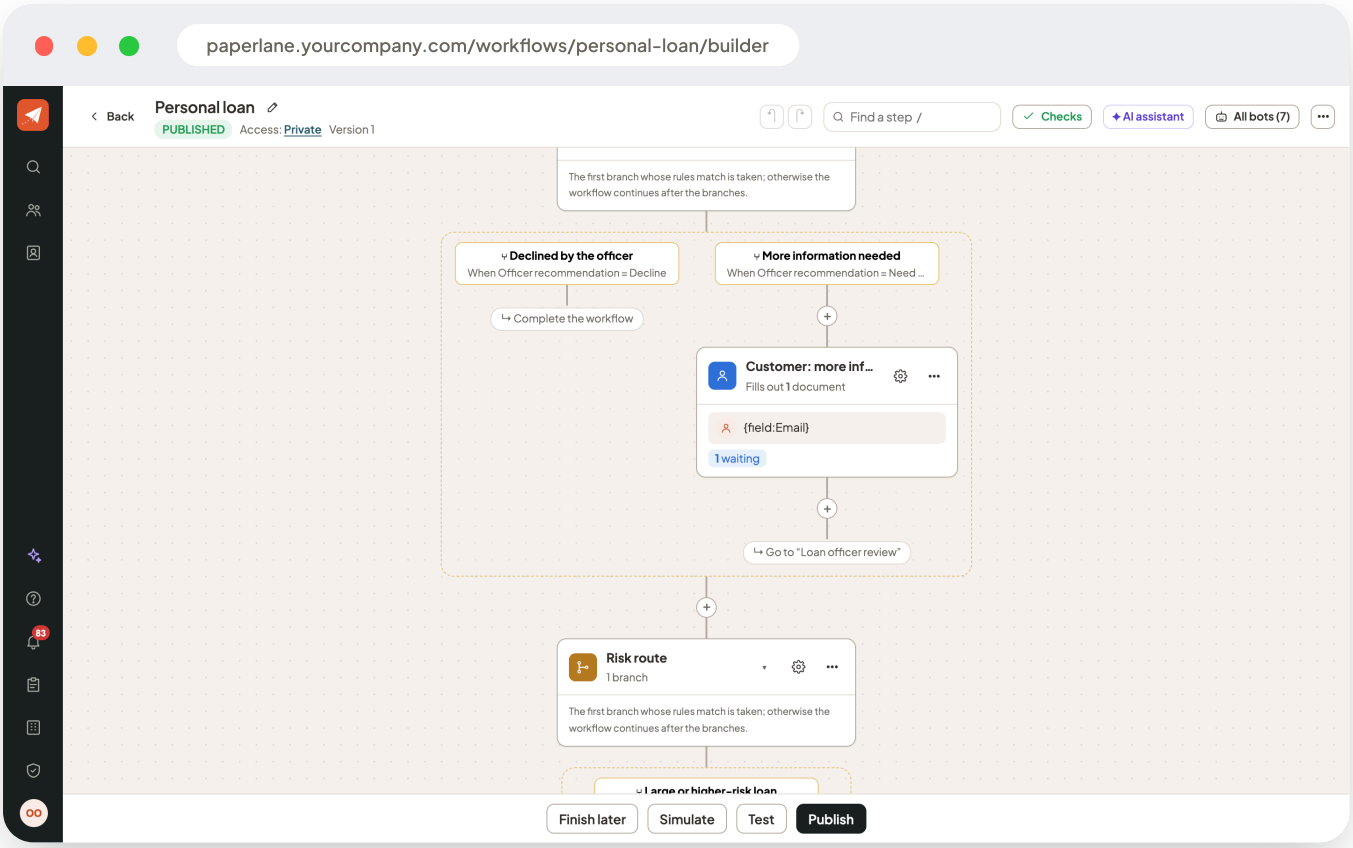
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WORKFLOW BUILDER

Draw the process

A workflow is a sequence of steps on a canvas. Each step names a recipient (a person, an email from a field, a group, a contact or anyone with the link) and which documents they fill in. Steps can be conditional, carry deadlines and run bots.

- Start from a public form, an autostart, an email or the API
- Group steps go to a work queue; deadlines are counted in business days
- Bots on a step: credit checks, naming, reference numbers, Word templates and more
- Checks, the AI assistant, undo and redo in the toolbar



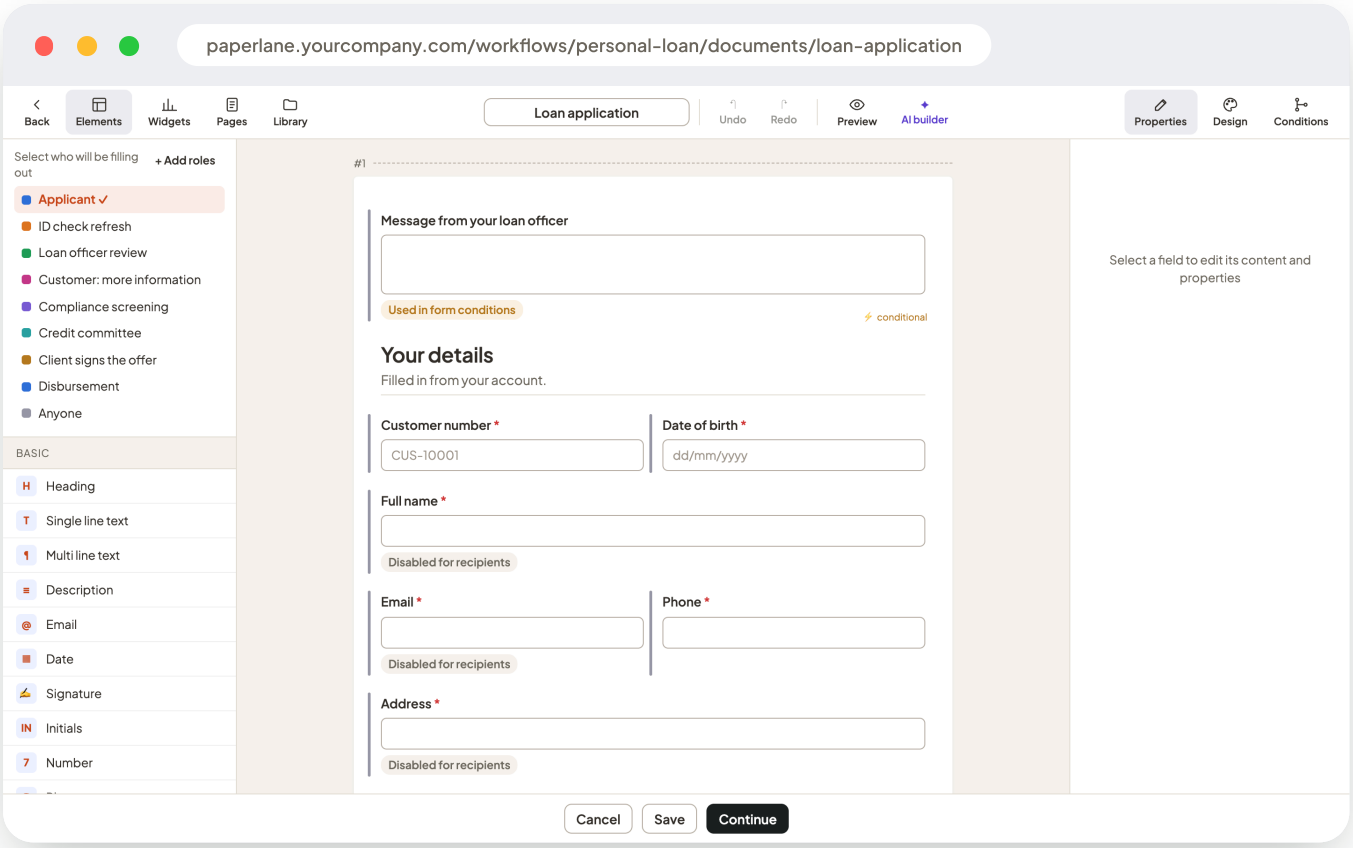
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BRANCHES AND LANES

Branches and lanes

Branches send each document down the lane whose rules match, so one workflow handles every outcome. Lanes can finish the workflow, loop back to an earlier step, or run in parallel. Simulate walks a document through without sending anything; Test sends every step to you.

- Rules on any field, the previous step's result, tags, dates or the recipient
- Jump back for missing information without restarting
- Publishing creates a new version; cases already in flight finish on the version they started on



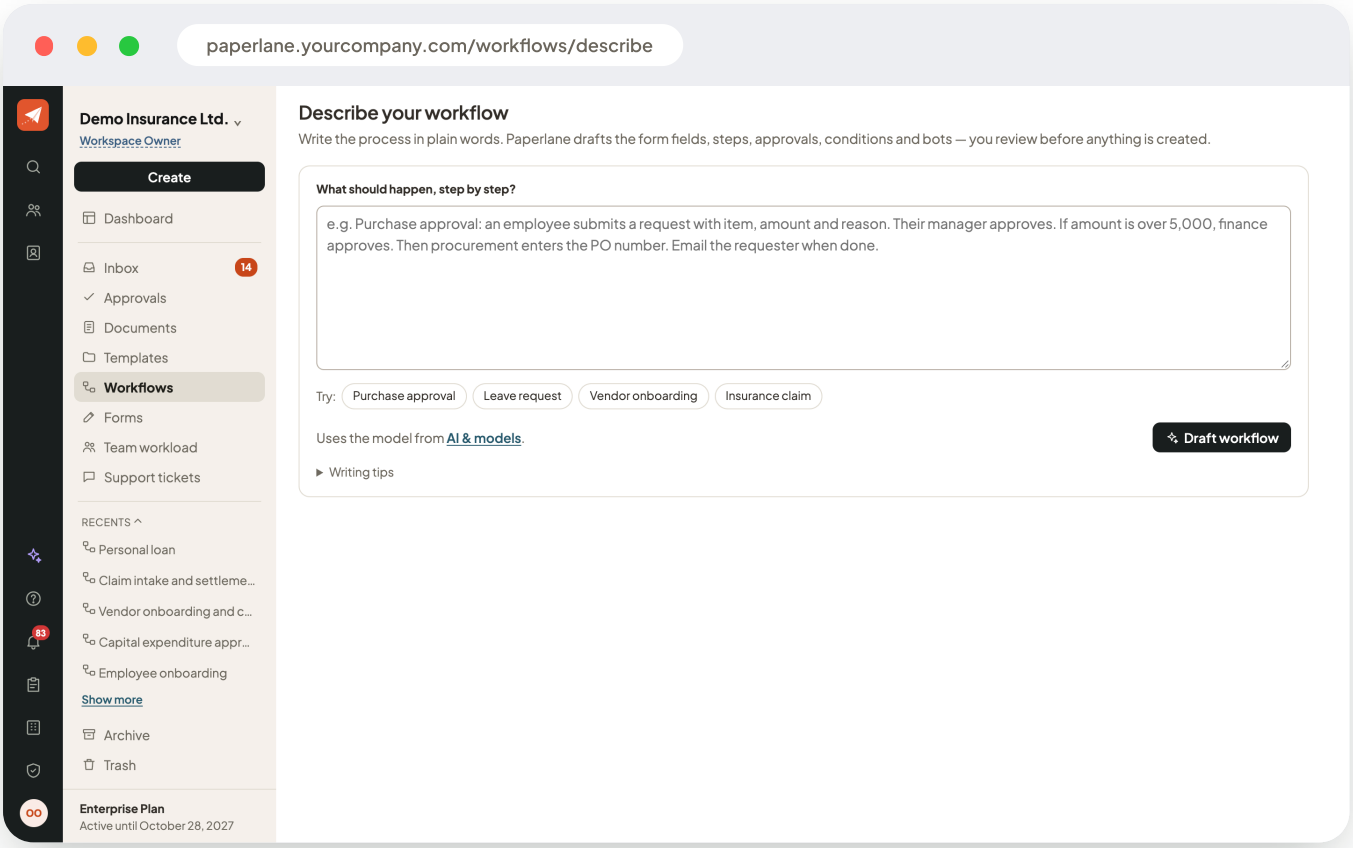
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FORM EDITOR

Design the forms

Documents are designed by dragging fields onto the page. Choose a recipient on the left to see and set exactly what they fill in; everything else is read-only or hidden for them.

- Text, numbers, currency, dates, choices, tables, signatures, initials, attachments and calculated fields
- Conditions show or hide fields based on other answers
- Sensitive fields are masked for anyone not involved
- Preview the form as each recipient sees it



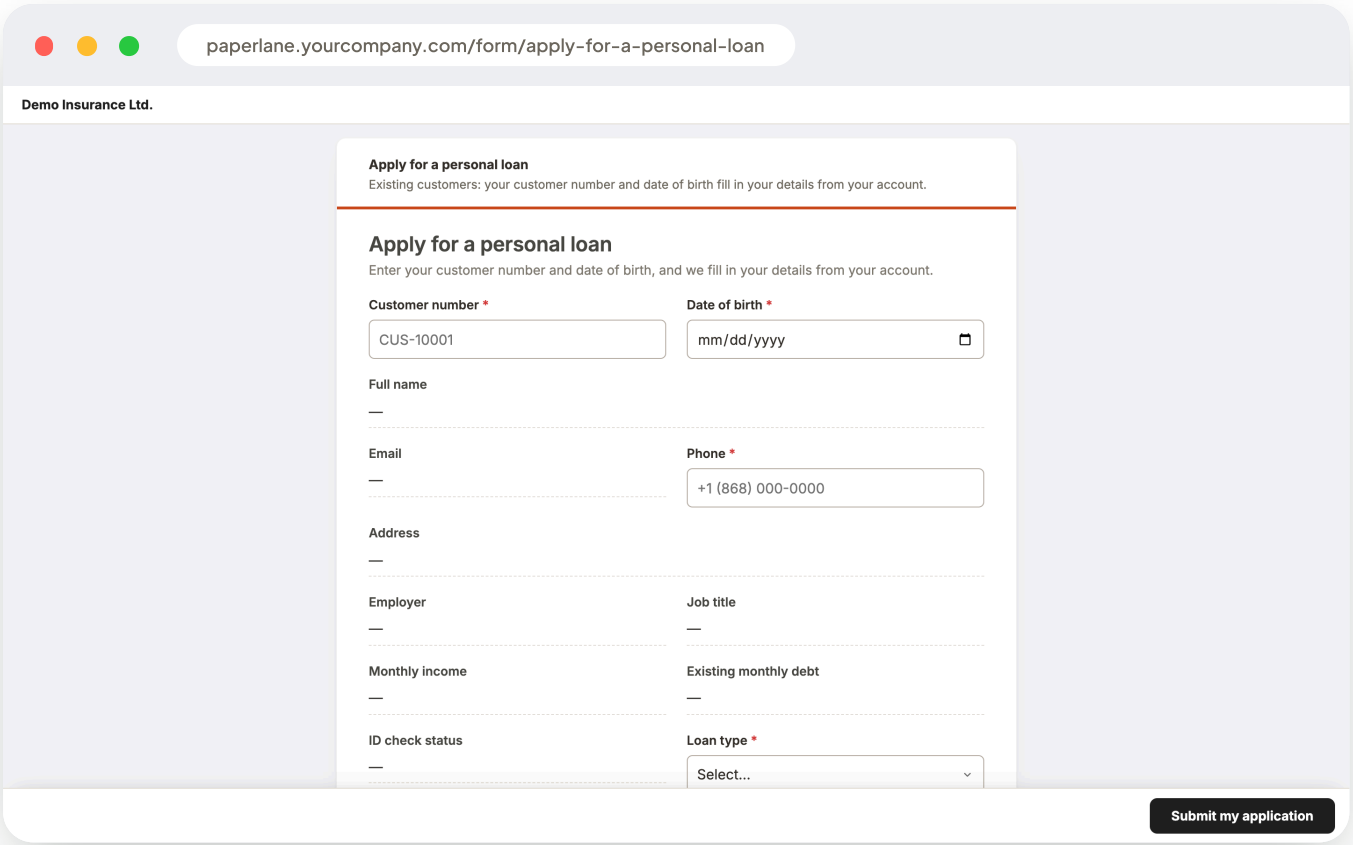
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AI WORKFLOW BUILDER

Or just describe it

Describe a process in plain words, or upload a paper form, PDF, Word file or photo, and Paperlane drafts the documents, steps, approvals, conditions and bots. You review every change before anything is created, and can undo it afterwards.

- Runs on a local model through Ollama, or a cloud model you choose
- Sensitive fields are never sent to a model
- An MCP server lets AI agents build workflows and complete steps with a person's permissions



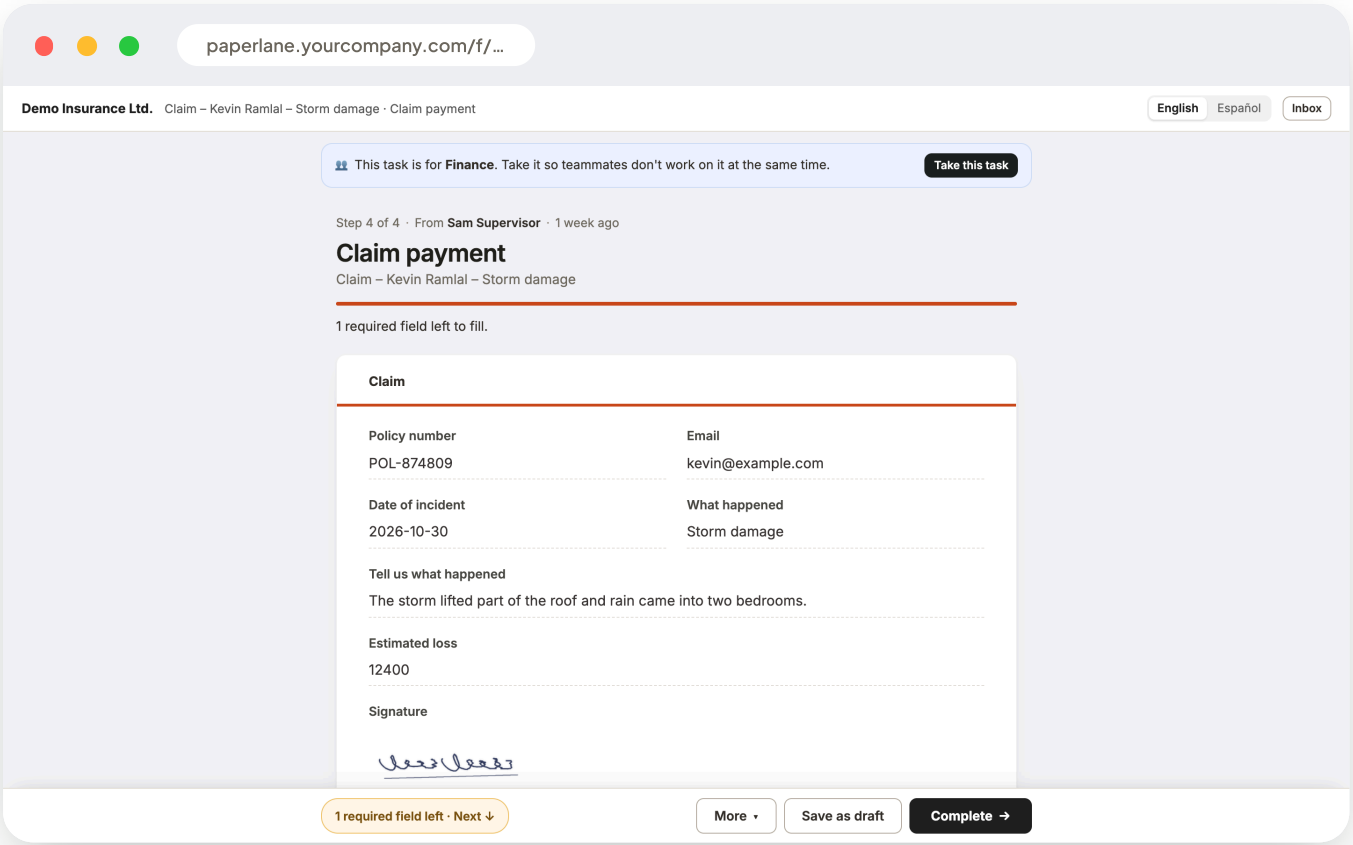
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PUBLIC START FORMS

Forms that fill themselves

A public form starts a new document. Look-ups call your own systems as people type: here the customer number and date of birth find the customer in core banking and fill in their details, so the form only asks for what is new.

- Look-ups from your API, a read-only database, a spreadsheet or past documents
- A look-up only answers when every key matches (here, number and date of birth)
- Duplicate detection can flag a second application for the same customer



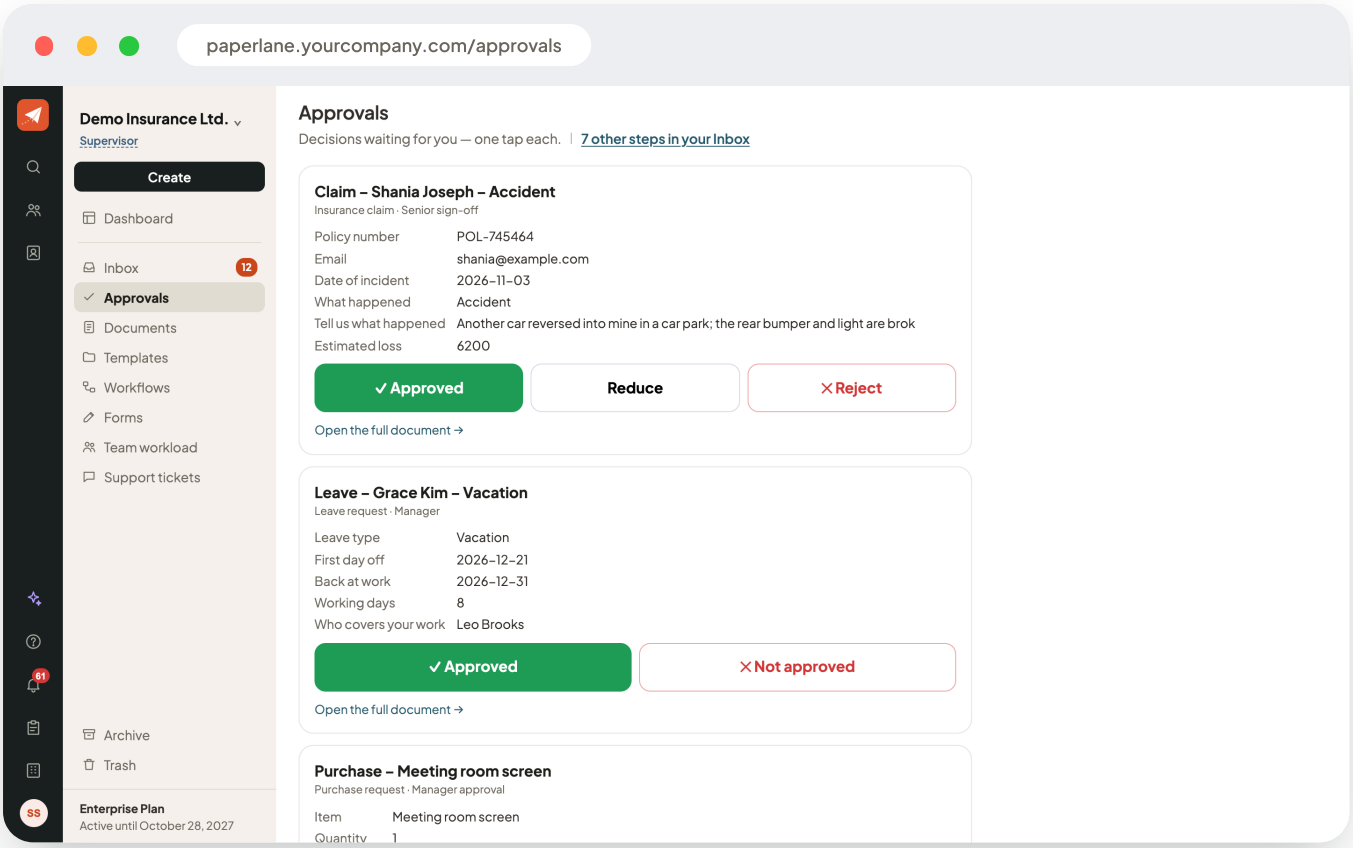
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FILLING A STEP

Fill and sign, no account needed

Recipients open a secure link; no account is needed. They see what earlier steps filled in, complete their part and sign. A step can require an identity check by email or text code first.

- Drafts, a required-fields guide and attachments that survive a failed submit
- English and Spanish for recipients
- Group steps: one teammate takes the task so nobody works on it twice
- One-tap decisions straight from the invitation email



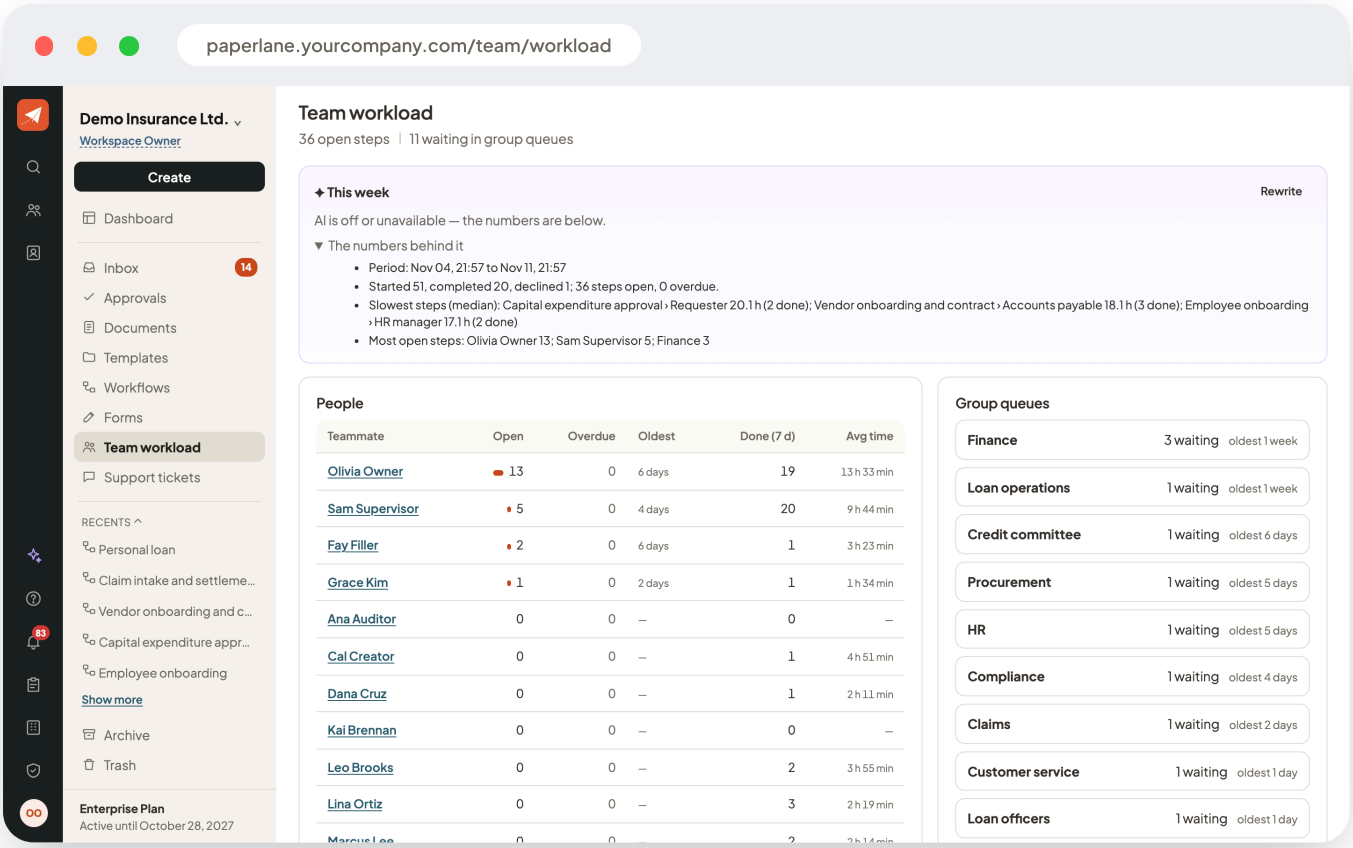
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QUICK APPROVALS

Approve in one tap

Steps whose only job is a decision appear on the approvals page with their key facts, sensitive values masked. One tap approves, declines or picks any other option, on a desktop or a phone.

- Built for phones
- A required comment is asked for before deciding
- Two people deciding the same group task at once: it advances once, the second is told who got there first, and the audit trail shows one approval



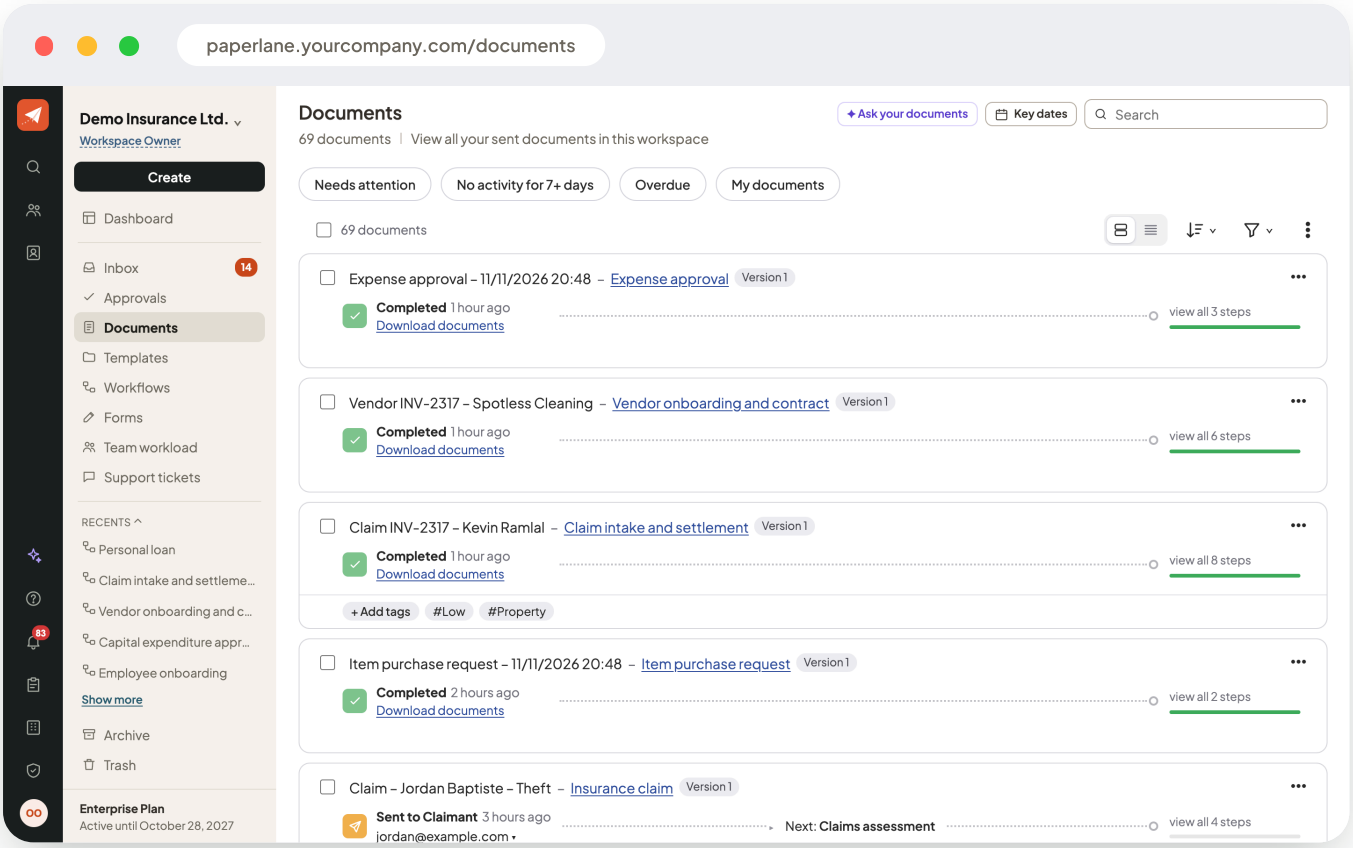
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TEAM WORKLOAD

See who has what

See every open step by person and by group queue, with what is overdue and how long the oldest has waited, so work can be rebalanced before deadlines slip.

- Reminders, reassignment and escalation when a deadline passes
- Out-of-office delegation routes new work to a cover
- A weekly summary of throughput and slow steps



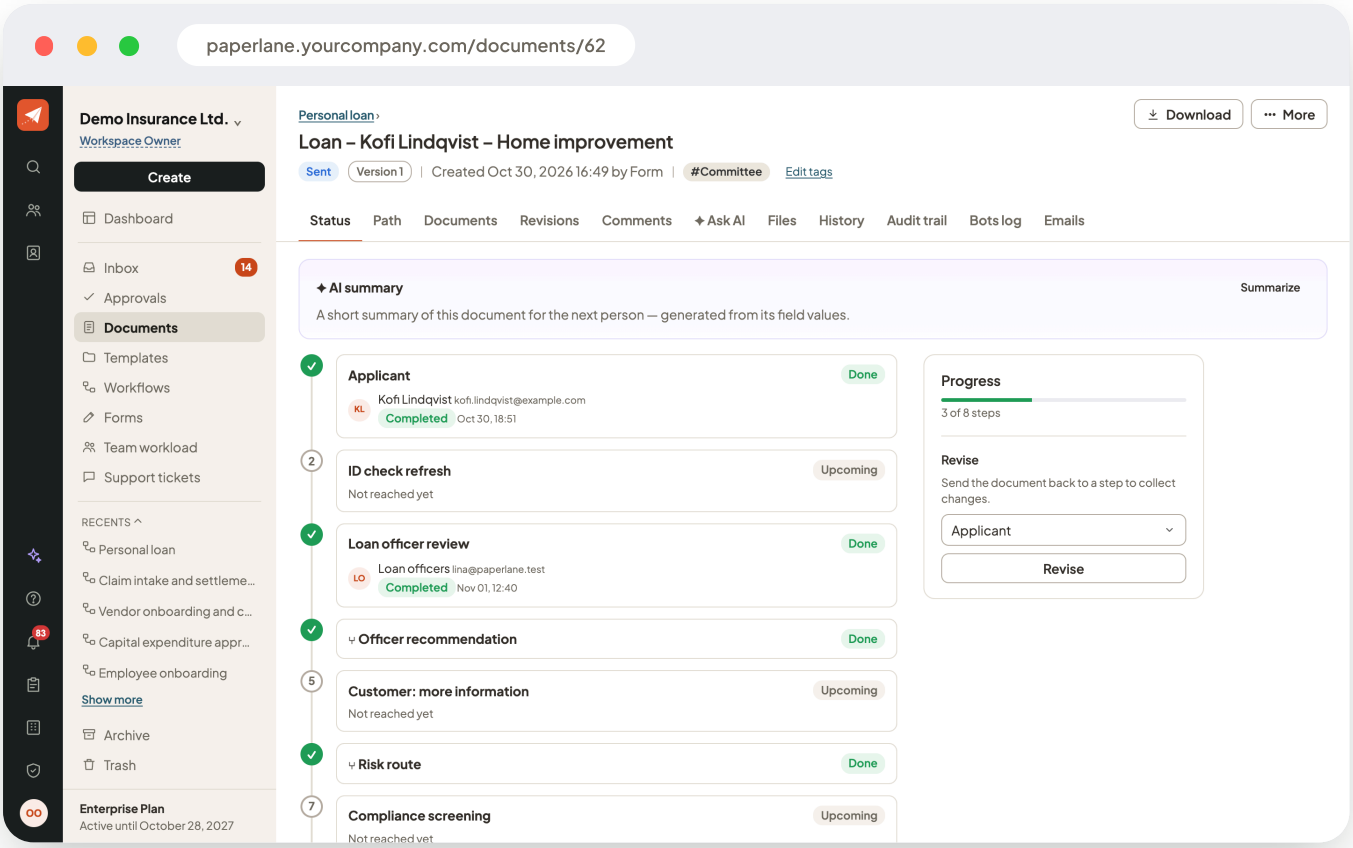
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DOCUMENTS

Every document, in one list

Every case in one list with its status, current step, holder and progress. Saved filters find what needs attention, is overdue or has gone quiet; Ask your documents answers questions in plain words.

- Search, tags, sort and bulk actions
- Key dates such as renewals and expiries
- Archive and trash with retention rules



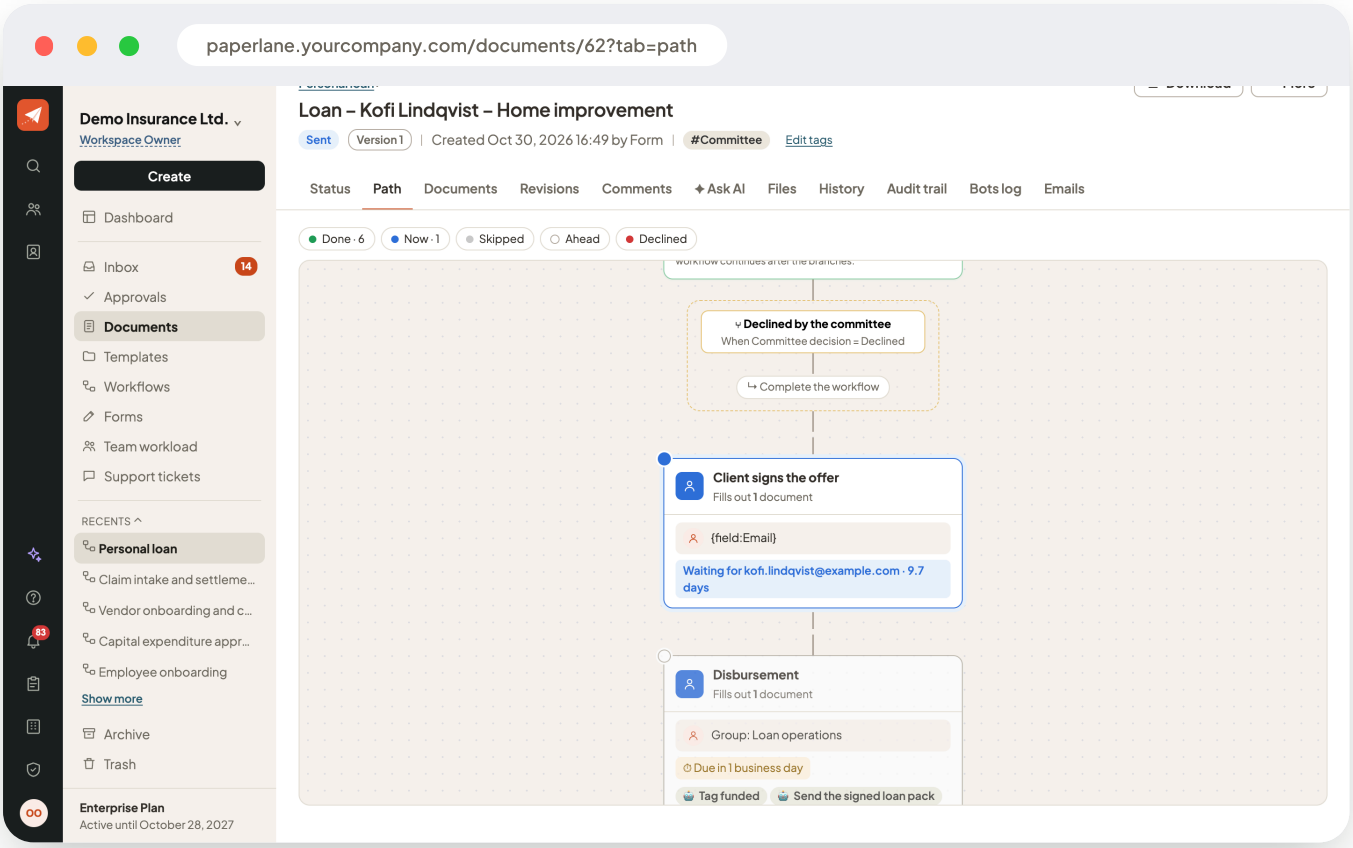
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ONE DOCUMENT

One application, step by step

A document's status page shows each step with who completed it and when, and what is still to come. Revise sends it back to an earlier step to collect changes.

- Tabs for the path, documents, revisions, comments, files, history, audit trail, bots log and emails
- An AI summary for the next person
- Download the documents or the sealed PDF



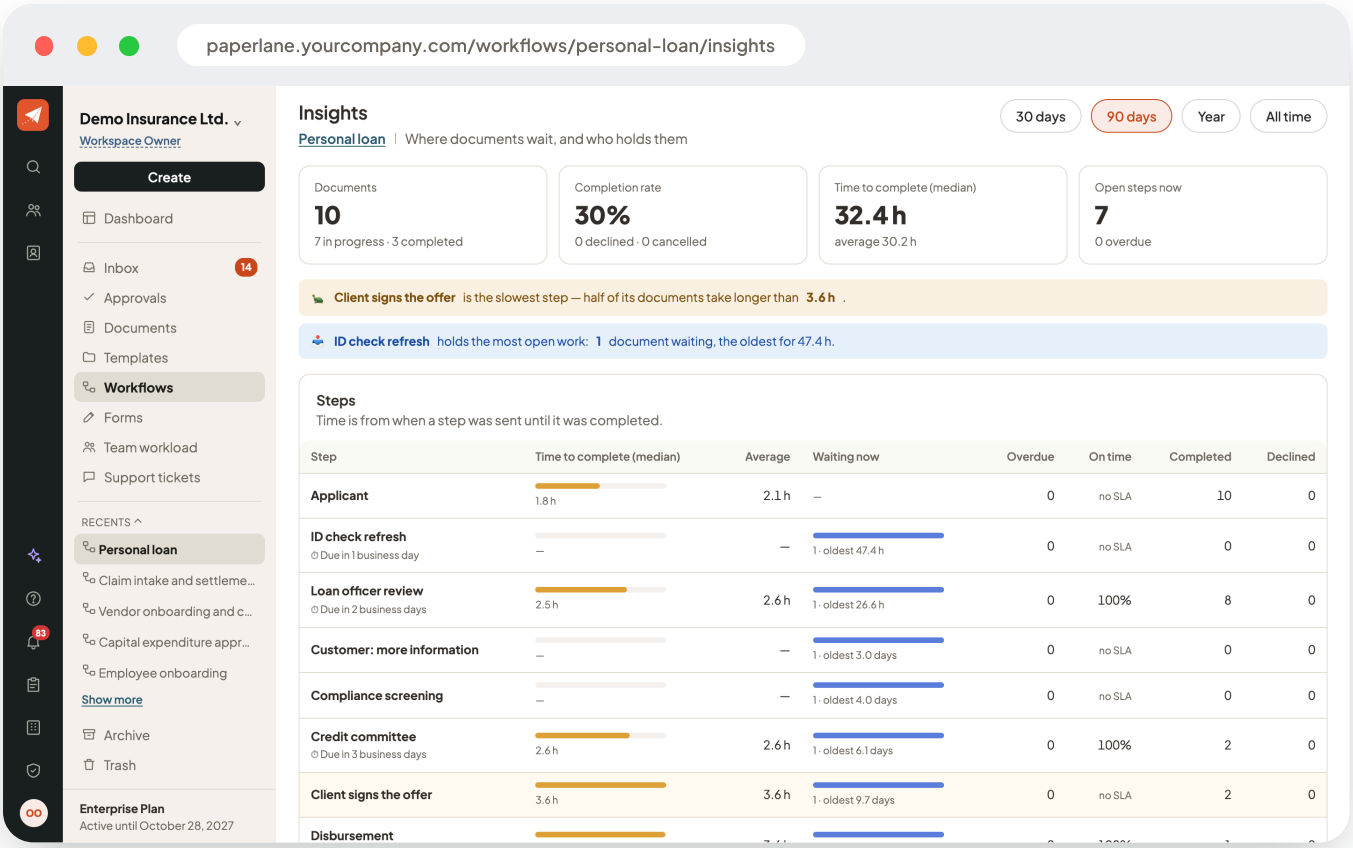
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PATH

The path it took

The path view draws the workflow for this one document: the steps that are done, the one it is waiting on now, and the branches and steps it skipped.

- Done, now, skipped, ahead and declined at a glance
- Shows how long the current step has been waiting



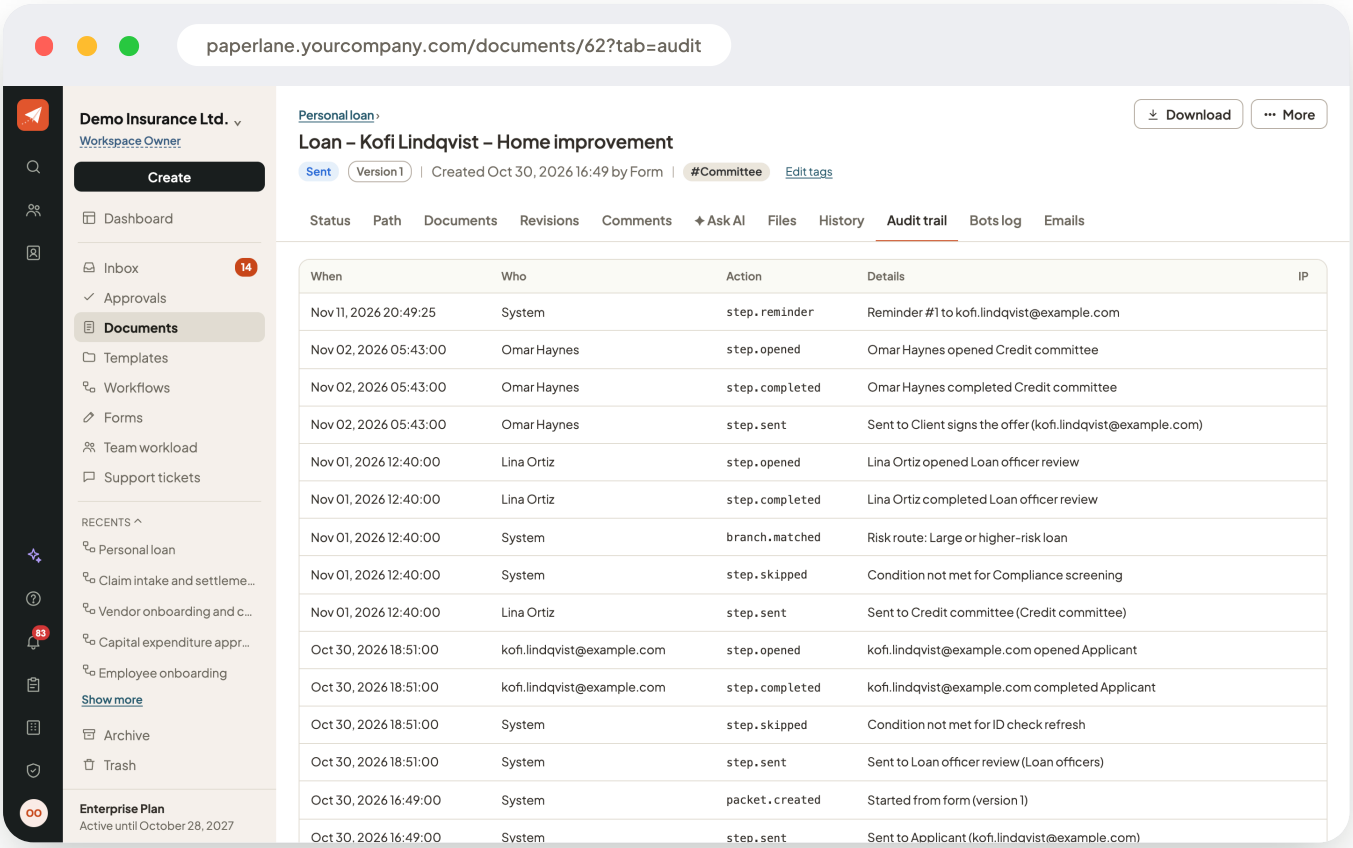
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INSIGHTS

Find the bottleneck

Workflow insights show completion rate, time to complete and open steps for any period, call out the slowest step and the step holding the most work, and break down time and deadline performance for every step.

- 30 days, 90 days, a year or all time
- Median and average time per step, on-time rate and declines
- Export to CSV



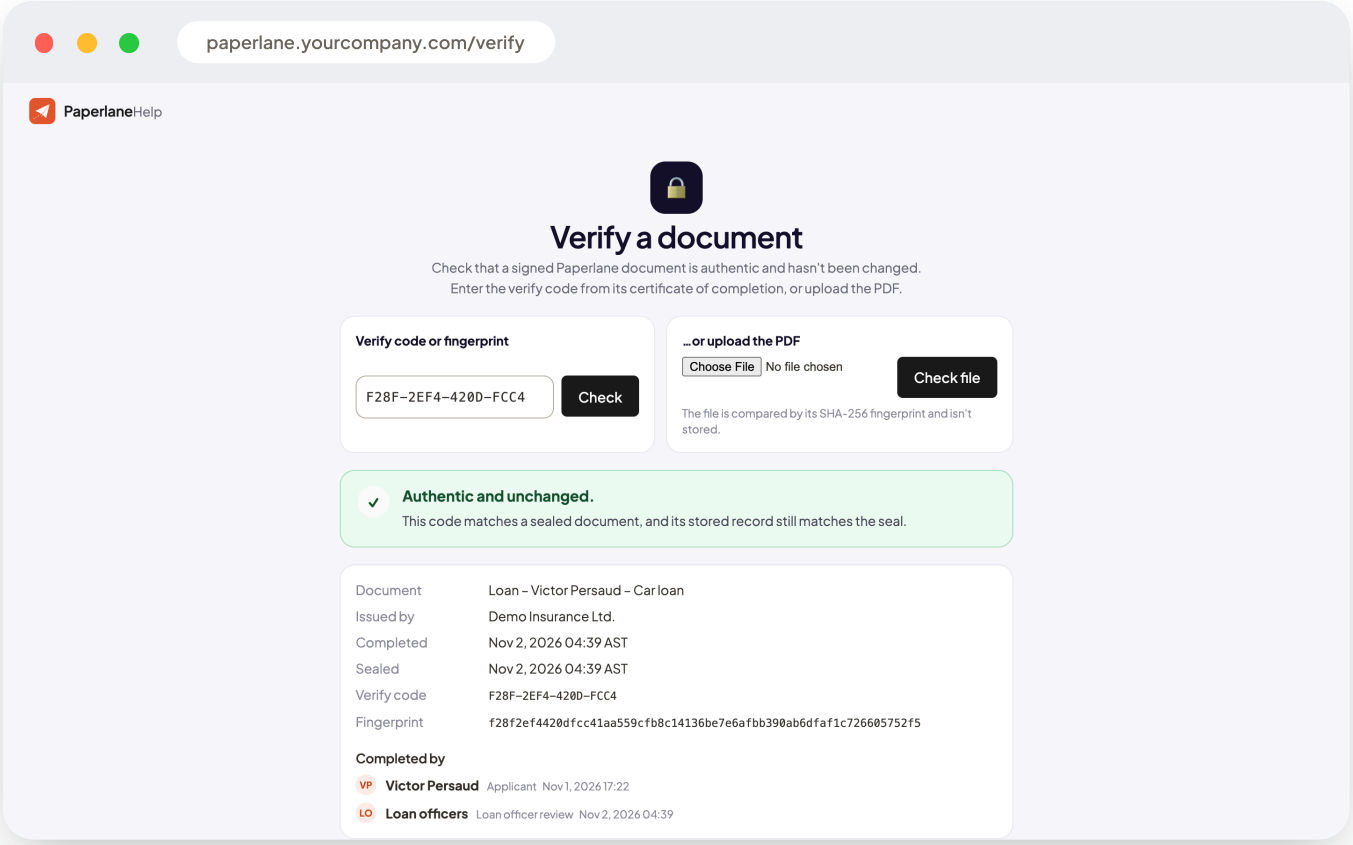
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AUDIT TRAIL

An audit trail you can hand over

Every action on a document is recorded with who did it, when and from where: sent, opened, completed, skipped, branch taken, reminders and more. The field history keeps every value change with who made it and whether a person, a step or a bot changed it.

- Sensitive values masked for people not involved, in exports too
- Retention schedules and legal hold
- Roles, groups, two-step sign-in and single sign-on (Entra ID, Google, Okta)



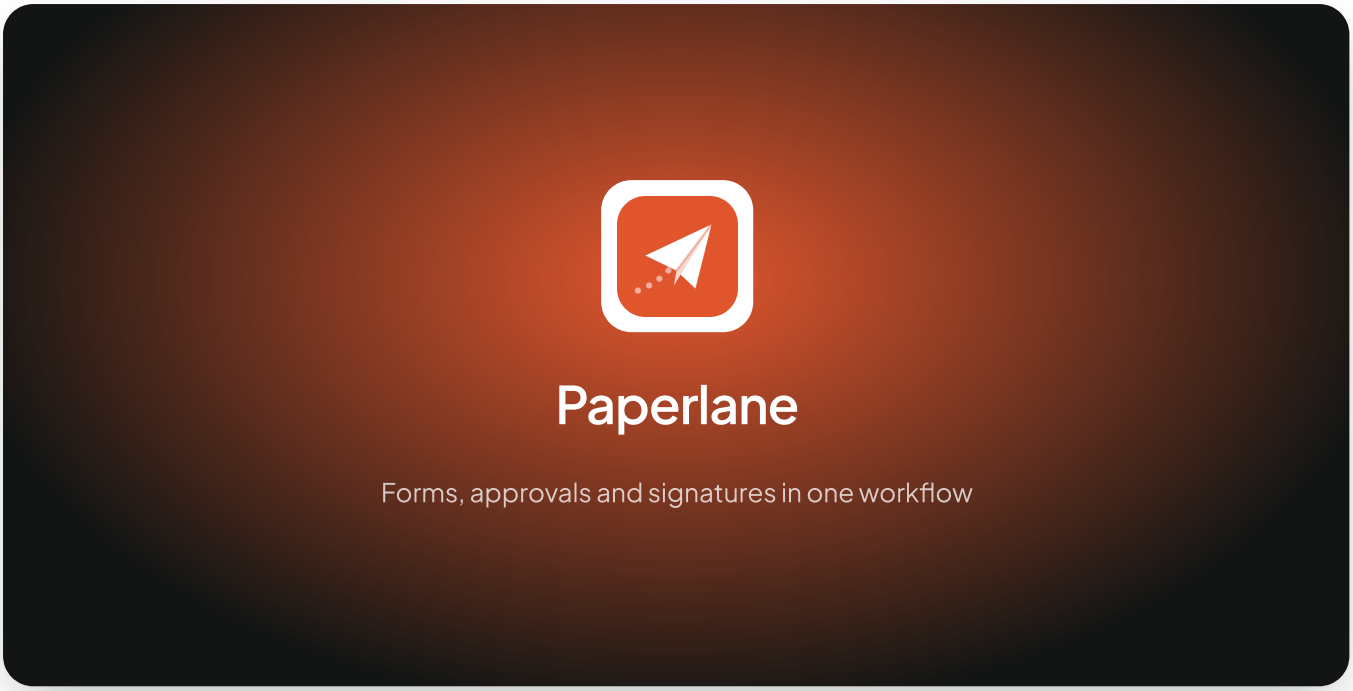
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VERIFY

Prove it hasn't changed

When a document completes, Paperlane seals it with a SHA-256 fingerprint and adds a certificate with a verify code to the PDF. Anyone can check the code or upload the PDF to confirm it is authentic and unchanged; if any stored value changed after sealing, the page says so.

- A public verify page, no account needed
- The uploaded PDF is compared by fingerprint and not stored
- Revised and re-completed documents get a new seal; earlier seals are kept



GET PAPERLANE

Run it on your own servers.

Paperlane is free and open source under AGPL-3.0. Try it locally with the demo data in a couple of minutes, then deploy it on a server with one script that sets up PostgreSQL, a jobs worker, backups and automatic HTTPS.

- Website: **paperlane.insightfusiontech.com**
- Code: **github.com/surenjanath/paperlane**
- Local: `pip install -r requirements.txt`, `migrate`, `seed_demo`, `runserver`
- Server: `sudo ./deploy/install.sh --domain docs.example.com`



Thank you

This guide followed one loan application through Paperlane: building the workflow and its forms, collecting the application, deciding in one tap, tracking every step, and proving the final record hasn't changed.

Try it yourself at **paperlane.insightfusiontech.com** · code at **github.com/surenjanath/paperlane**

FORMS, APPROVALS AND SIGNATURES IN ONE WORKFLOW